



Inability to adapt: England was undone by “super extreme” conditions in its Test defeat by India, said captain Heather Knight (middle). EMMANUAL YOGINI

“Maybe if we had a two- or three-match series, we’d be able to use these lessons and get better.”

That suggestion makes former India women’s coach and veteran cricketer WV Raman smile.

“I am sure that even the solitary Test played is happening after a lot of conversations back and forth. If we get anything more than a single Test, and if we get a two- or three-match series, I will be incredibly surprised. That can only happen if more than three or four countries want this for the game. Otherwise, allegations of just these top countries getting everything will understandably crop up.”

From domestic to international

Kulkarni belongs to an era where Tests were part and parcel of the experience of international cricket. She was the first Indian woman to

score a half-century and take five wickets in a single Test, a feat Deepti Sharma emulated against England in the recently concluded Test.

However, as an administrator, she sees merit in going the white-ball way when the first task is to popularise the game as widely as possible.

“When I was in the ICC Women’s Committee, before the merger with the ICC, a lot of Tests were played, but when women’s cricket came under the ICC, T20s and ODIs became the priority. That move is helping the game grow, so when authorities make decisions, they look at data points, economics, and more. Sponsorship, affordability, and coverage will all be important points,” she explains.

It’s easy to see the parallels in England, which, along with Australia, has pioneered how women’s cricket is promoted, with offerings like The Hundred.

“We’re seeing the Hundred; we have T10. People are going shorter and shorter with game formats as

well. So how is that surge balanced with this need to revive and maintain Test cricket is one we’ll have to watch out for,” she adds.

Before the lone Test, vice-captain Smriti Mandhana said that domestic structures follow the demands of the international scene. With white-ball cricket being the order of business, the choice trickles down to the grassroots.

“To be fair, the domestic structure was formed based on one-day and T20 because those are the World Cups that are frequent at the international level. I’ve just played four Tests in 10 odd years of international cricket. Maybe we’ll see a new tournament at the domestic level. But the domestic scene will change itself according to what the international demands are,” Mandhana had said before the game.

Both Raman and Kulkarni believe that the domestic scene can set the pace.

“We have been proposing a two-day tournament at the